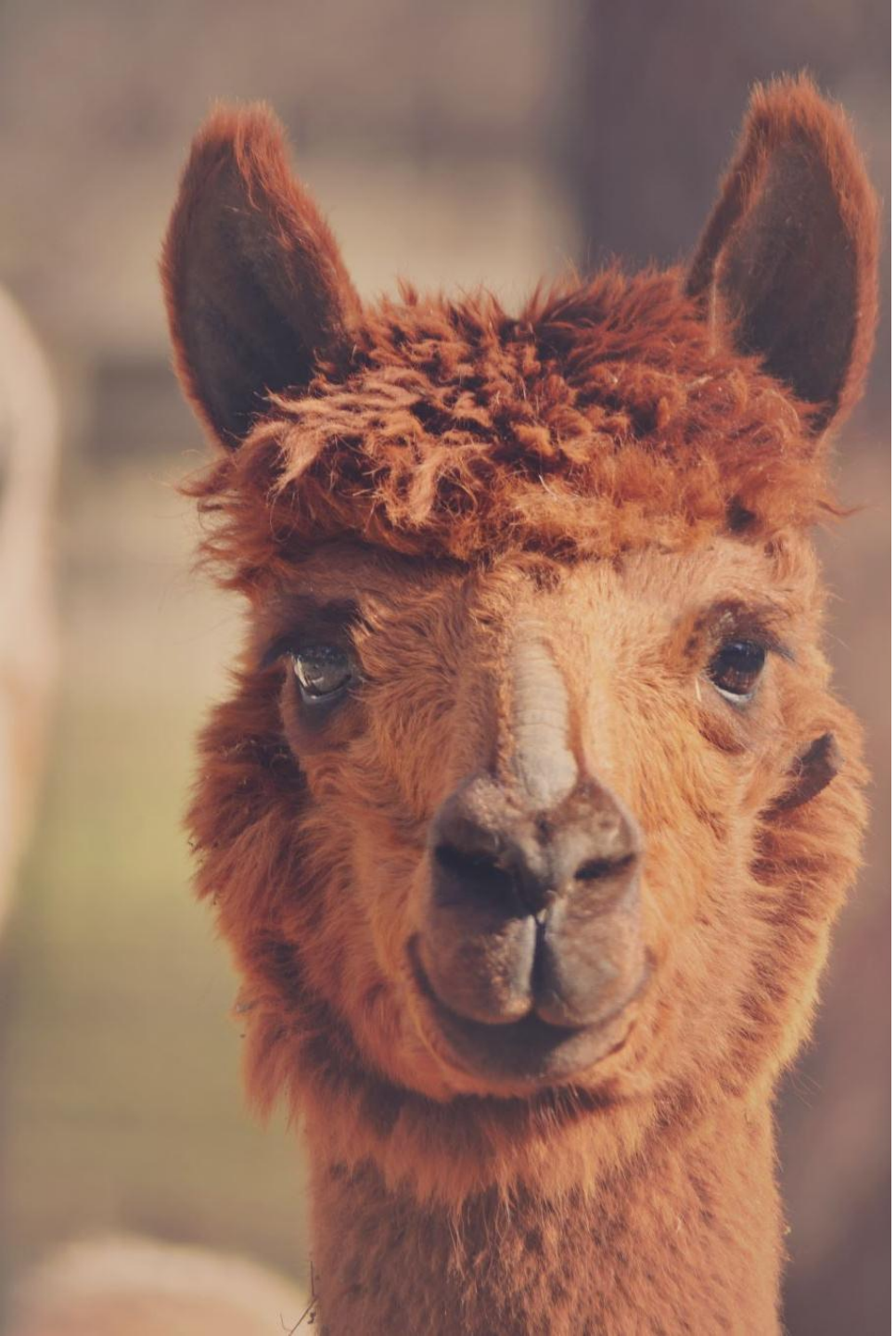


Grammar & Basics

If-Conditionals

Talking about conditions

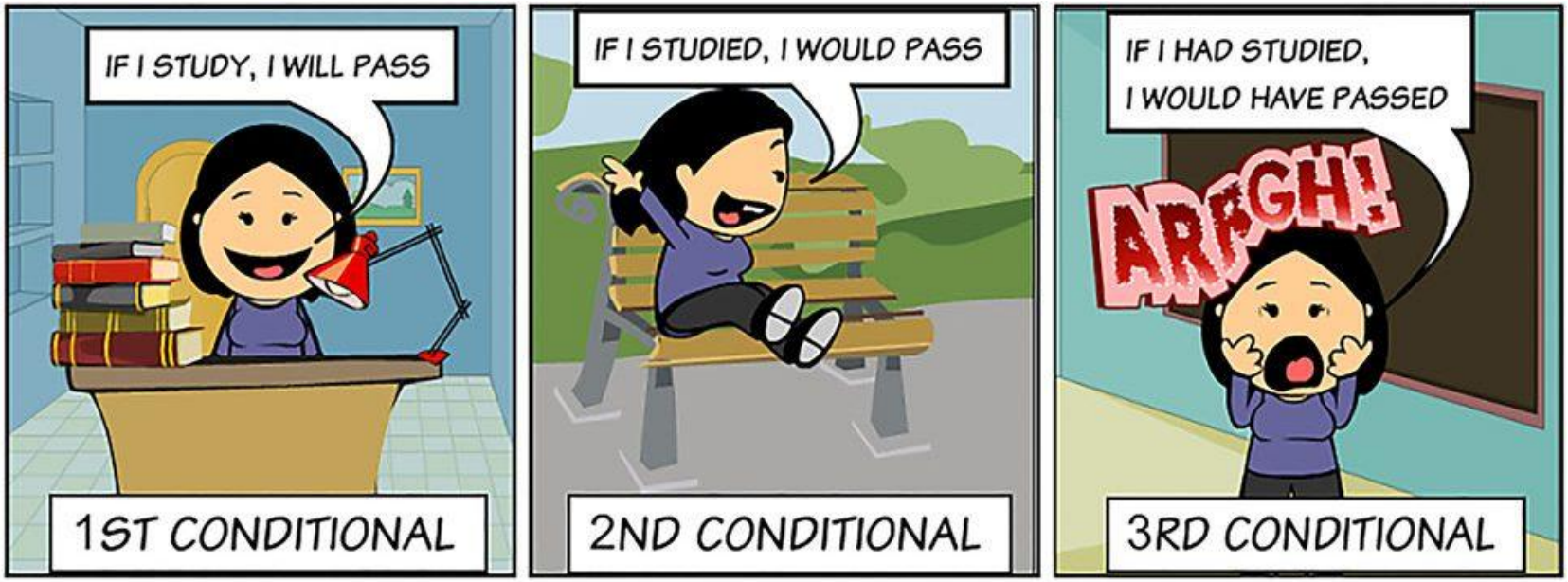
There are three main types, which are used to express different things.

In pairs, discuss your intuitive understanding of how they differ.

1. If we **buy** a dishwasher, we **will save** time
2. If I **won** a million dollars, I **would quit** my job
3. If she **had taken** a taxi, she **would have arrived** there in time

If-Conditionals

In English you often talk about the outcome of certain conditions in sentences with ‘if…’



Type 1

"If we **buy** a dishwasher, we **will** save time"

Present form (buy) in the if-part

This means that it is <u>likely</u> that we will buy a dishwasher

The result in the other part is also <u>likely</u> to happen

That's indicated by will + verb (will save) in the other part

Type 2

- “If I **won** a million dollars, I **would quit** my job”
- Past form (**won**) in the if part
- This means that it is **<u>unlikely</u>** that I would win a million dollars
- The result in the other part is also **<u>unlikely</u>** to happen
- That’s indicated by **would + verb (would quit)** in the other part

Type 2

- Also used for things that are **impossible** to happen
  - If I **ruled** the world, we **would have** 4 day-weekends

- If you use it in this way you always use **were** as the past form of (to) be (not **was)**
  - If I **were** a wizard, I **would go** to Hogwarts.

Type 1 and 2 compared

1. If he **works** hard he **will pass** his exam
   - In the first example you are talking about an active student who is likely to work hard (and therefore pass the exam)

2. If he **worked** hard he **would pass** his exam
   - In the second example you are talking about a student who is unlikely to work hard for whatever reason (and therefore unlikely to pass his exam)

Type 3

- “If she **had taken** a taxi, she **would** have **been** there in time.”

- The past form with had (had taken) in the if part

- This indicates you are <u>talking about the past</u>, so she **can’t take a taxi anymore**
- You can **speculate** about what if she had
- This is indicated by would have + verb + ed (for irregular verbs, 3rd column)

Type 1, 2 and 3 compared

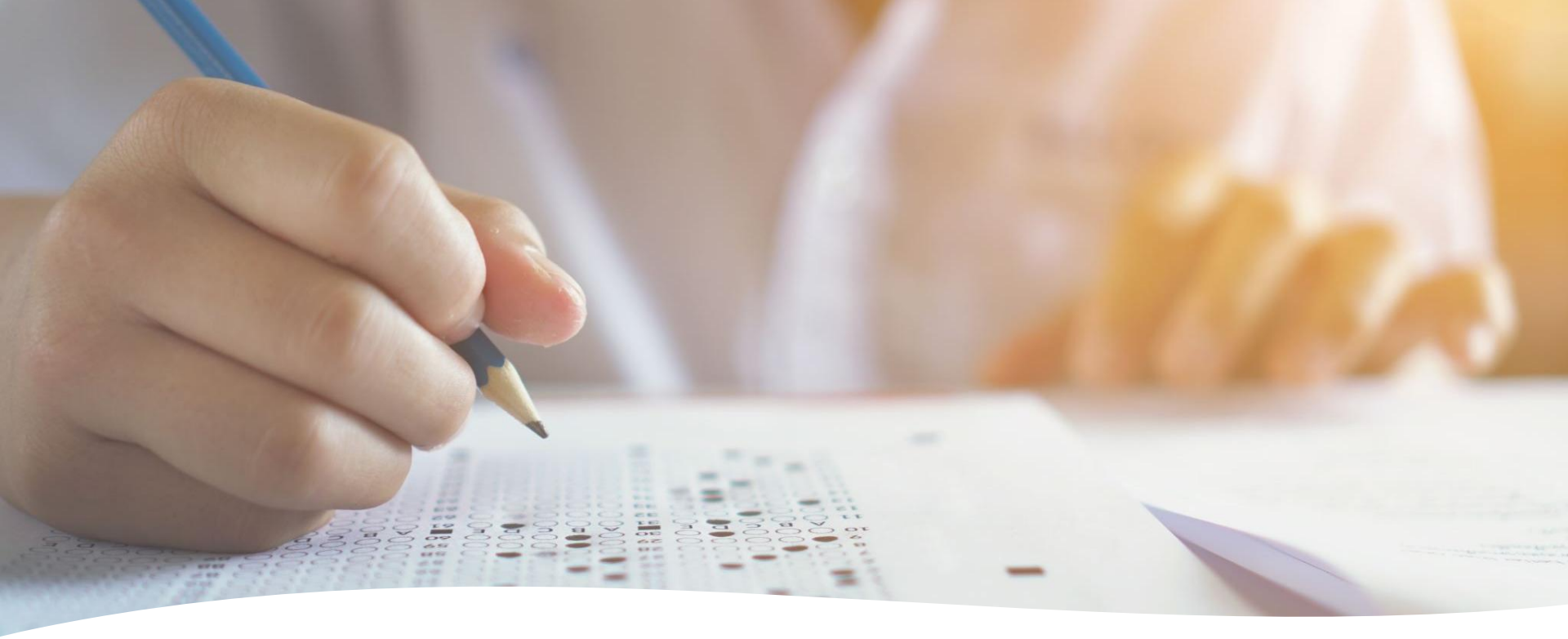
1. If you **give** me money, you **will get** a higher mark.
2. If you **gave** me money, you **would get** a higher mark.
3. If you **had given** me money, you **would have got** a higher mark.

Type 1

- If you **give** me money, you **will get** a higher mark.
- This indicates that you're likely to give me money and as a result get a higher mark.

Type 2

- If you **gave** me money, you **would get** a higher mark.
- This indicates that you're unlikely to give me money (and as a result I'm unlikely to give you a higher mark)



Type 3

- If you **had given** me money, you **would have received** a higher mark.
- This indicates that the exam results are already processed, so the moment to give me money is already over.

Giving teachers money

- Unfortunately for you none of this is true, because
  - If I **were** in it for the money, I **would**n't **be** a teacher.

Do not use ‘will’ or ‘would’ in the if-part

1. ~~If it will rain, I will bring an umbrella~~
   If it rains, I will bring an umbrella
2. ~~If he would clean up, he wouldn’t lose his stuff.~~
   If he cleaned up, he wouldn’t lose his stuff.

1. ~~If he would have called, I would have come to the right place~~
   If he had called, I would have come to the right place

The order of the parts can be changed

- If it rains, I will bring an umbrella →
  I will bring an umbrella if it rains.

- He wouldn’t lose his stuff if he cleaned up. →
  If he cleaned up, he wouldn’t lose his stuff.

- I would have come to the right place if he had called me →
  If he had called, I would have come to the right place

Exercise: Correct the incorrect conditional

1. If knew she was ill, I would have sent her some flowers.
2. If my flat has a balcony, I would grow plans in pots on them.
3. Where will you like to live if you could choose?
4. I can’t see Mary. If she is taller, I could see her.
5. If I played better, the team would have won the match.
6. If I catch the train at one, I would arrive in time
7. I would buy organic food if it is cheaper. At the moment it is too expensive.
8. She wouldn’t have gone to University if she didn’t work hard at school.
9. If you had lived tow hundred years ago, what would you do?

Exercise: answers

1. If I **had known** she was ill, I would have sent her some flowers.
2. If my flat **had** a balcony, I would grow plans in pots on them.
3. Where **would** you like to live if you could choose?
4. I can't see Mary. If she **were** taller, I could see her.
5. If I **had played** better, the team would have won the match.
6. If I catch the train at one, I **will** arrive in time
7. I would buy organic food if it **was** cheaper. At the moment it is too expensive.
8. She wouldn't have gone to University if she **hadn't worked** hard at school.
9. If you had lived tow hundred years ago, what would you **have done**?

Exercise: Finish the conditional

1. If it is sunny tomorrow _____
2. If you sit in the sun too long _____
3. If I were you _____
4. If I were the Prime Minister _____
5. If she had studied harder _____
6. If I won the lottery _____
7. If I hadn’t gone to bed so late _____
8. If I hadn’t come to London _____
9. If you mix water and electricity _____
10. If she hadn’t stayed at home _____

Finish the conditional (example)

1. If it **is** sunny tomorrow, **we'll go** to the park.
2. If you **sit** in the sun too long , you **get burned**.
3. If I **were** you, I **would go** out tonight.
4. If I **were** the Prime Minister, I **would make** the museums free.
5. If she **had studied** harder, she **would have passed** the exam.
6. If I **won** the lottery, I **would buy** a big house.
7. If I **hadn’t gone** to bed so late, I **wouldn't have been** tired.
8. If I **hadn’t come** to London, I **would have gone** to New York.
9. If you **mix** water and electricity, you **get** a shock.
10. If she **hadn’t stayed** at home, she **would have gone** shopping